

GOV.UK Content Design Manual — Curated PDF Version

For governance pages, crypto apps, and citizen-facing services

Compiled by Microsoft Copilot for Nurul

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1. Writing Standards

- Use **plain English**: short sentences, everyday words, and active voice.
 - Avoid jargon, acronyms, and technical terms unless essential.
 - Prioritize **clarity over cleverness**—users scan, not read deeply.
 - Use **headings and subheadings** to break up content.
 - Write for **screen readers**: avoid ambiguous phrasing and nested clauses.
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2. Links and Buttons

- Use **descriptive link text**: e.g. “Download the CPF guide” instead of “Click here.”
 - Avoid vague CTAs like “Read more” or “Learn more.”
 - Buttons should:
 - Be **visually distinct** and accessible via keyboard
 - Use **action-oriented labels**: “Submit application,” “Check eligibility”
 - Never rely on color alone to convey meaning.
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3. Images and Alt Text

- Only use images when they **add value** or clarify content.
 - Alt text must:
 - Describe the image’s **purpose**, not just its appearance
 - Be **concise and relevant** to the surrounding content
 - Decorative images should use `alt=""` to be skipped by screen readers.
 - Avoid text embedded in images unless absolutely necessary.
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4. Content Types and Formats

- Use the correct GOV.UK format:
 - **Guidance**: step-by-step instructions
 - **News**: time-sensitive updates
 - **Blogs**: informal, narrative content
 - Structure content using:
 - **Bullet points** for scannability
 - **Tables** for comparisons
 - **Code blocks** for technical instructions
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5. User Needs and Content Planning

- Start with a **user need statement**:
“As a [user], I need to [do something] so I can [achieve a goal].”
 - Prioritize content that helps users **complete tasks**.
 - Avoid publishing content that’s only informative but not actionable.
 - Use **version control** and document changes clearly.
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6. 📊 Research and Evidence

- Use analytics to identify:
 - High-traffic pages with poor engagement
 - Search terms that lead users to your content
 - Conduct **usability testing** with real users.
 - Optimize for **SEO**:
 - Use keywords naturally
 - Write meaningful page titles and meta descriptions
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7. 🛠️ Maintenance and Governance

- Review content regularly for:
 - Accuracy
 - Accessibility
 - Relevance
 - Withdraw outdated content with clear messaging.
 - Label content from previous governments or policy regimes.
 - During elections, follow **purdah guidelines** for publishing.
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📋 Appendix: Quick Checklist for Governance Pages

Element	Standard
Links	Descriptive, action-oriented, no “click here”
Buttons	Accessible, labeled with clear actions
Alt Text	Purpose-driven, concise, no decorative clutter
Headings	Hierarchical, scannable, meaningful
Language	Plain English, active voice, no jargon
Accessibility	Keyboard navigable, screen reader friendly
Maintenance	Versioned, reviewed, and labeled appropriately
